

SIERRA ASCENT

Master Expedition Report | 4-Day, 3-Night Loop Itinerary (Reno Base)

Santa Ana → Emerald Bay & Eagle Falls → Reno (base) → East Shore Tahoe → Sequoia National Park → Kings Canyon → Santa Ana

~1,400 mi TOTAL DRIVING DISTANCE	115 ft → 6,225 ft ELEVATION RANGE	6 L / person WATER REQUIRED	Reno Airbnb FRI & SAT LODGING
---	---	---------------------------------------	---

Departure: Friday, July 4, 2026 @ 12:00 AM (Midnight Thursday) | Return: Monday, July 7, 2026 @ ~5:30 PM

DAY 1 · WEST SHORE & THE DRIVE INTO RENO

Friday, July 4

12:00 AM

Depart Santa Ana

Drive straight up I-5 North and across to the West Shore of Lake Tahoe — with Burney Falls cut from the route, this leg is direct (no detour north), so plan on roughly 7–7.5 hours door to door.

7:00 AM

Emerald Bay Overlook

One of the most photographed views in the Sierra. Lake Tahoe is the largest alpine lake in North America and the second-deepest lake in the U.S. — you'll see why the water looks so impossibly clear here.

Bonus (time permitting): Vikingsholm, a 1929 Scandinavian-style mansion at the bottom of the bay, is reachable via a steep ~1-mile trail down (and back up).

8:00 AM

Eagle Falls Hike

The trailhead shares the same parking area as the Emerald Bay overlook, so there's no driving between the two. A moderate ~2-mile round trip gets you to the upper falls; continue on if you want to push to Eagle Lake.

11:30 AM

Drive to South Lake Tahoe

About 20–25 minutes south on Hwy 89 into South Lake Tahoe.

12:00 PM

Lunch — The Chateau at the Village

On Lake Tahoe Blvd near Heavenly Village/Stateline. It's a small dining-and-shops complex — Dumping 85 and McP's Irish Pub are both on site if you want to wander before deciding.

1:00 PM

Drive to Reno

About 1 hour via US-50 East over Spooner Summit and through Carson City, then north on US-395 into Reno.

This is the most direct way back — no need to retrace the morning's route.

2:00 PM

Arrive Reno — Settle into the Airbnb

Unpack, grab any groceries you still need, and rest up before cooking.

Evening

Cook Dinner & Recover

First real chance to sit down since the midnight drive — take it easy tonight.

DAY 2 · EAST SHORE, LINEAR FROM RENO

Saturday, July 5

7:00 AM

Depart Reno

Take Mt. Rose Highway (NV-431) toward Incline Village, about 40–45 minutes.

8:00 AM

Sand Harbor

Famous for its turquoise coves and granite boulders. Lake Tahoe's water is about 99.994% pure, which is exactly why it looks this clear.

Note: Nevada State Parks requires a day-use reservation (reservenevada.com) for entry before 10:30 AM during peak season and on holiday weekends — book ahead for this July 4th-weekend Saturday.

11:00 AM

Secret Cove

About 20 minutes further south on Hwy 28. A short trail down to a hidden, Caribbean-colored cove.

1:00 PM

Skunk Harbor

Roughly a 1.5-mile hike each way down an old logging road — look for remnants of an 1870s railroad grade along the way. The cove at the bottom has a stone picnic house built in the 1920s by a San Francisco family. No restrooms or trash service, so pack a picnic and pack out what you bring.

3:30 PM

Drive Toward Cave Rock

Continue south on Hwy 28/50 toward the south end of the East Shore, about 20–25 minutes.

7:30 PM

Cave Rock Sunset Scramble

A short, steep climb for a 180-degree sunset view over the Sierra — the last stop of the day.

8:00 PM

Drive Back to Reno

About 1 hour via US-50 East over Spooner Summit and Carson City. Same Airbnb as Friday night — just head straight back, no check-in needed.

DAY 3 · THE LONG HAUL TO SEQUOIA

Sunday, July 6

7:30 AM

Depart Reno

Heads up: starting from Reno instead of South Lake Tahoe adds real drive time — figure roughly 6–7.5 hours depending on route (via South Lake Tahoe & Carson Pass/Hwy 88, or via I-80 & CA-99). Leaving earlier than originally planned keeps the afternoon intact.

Flag for you: let me know if you'd rather adjust this leg further — e.g., a brief stop in South Lake Tahoe on the way out, or a different route entirely.

~2:00 PM

Kaweah River & Redwoods

Cool off after the long drive with a swim in the emerald Kaweah River swimming holes. Climb the handrail-assisted staircase of Moro Rock and stand beneath the colossal General Sherman Tree.

Evening

Check in — Sequoia Area

Settle into your local Sequoia hotel for the night.

Cold weather warning: temperatures plummet once the sun dips beneath the giant forest canopy. Dry off completely after swimming and shift directly into warm hoodies, fleeces, and pants to avoid hypothermia risk.

DAY 4 · THE KINGS CANYON GRAND FINALE & RETURN

Monday, July 7

8:00 AM

Drive to Kings Canyon

Head directly to neighboring Kings Canyon National Park, only about 30 miles from Sequoia's northern gates.

9:00 AM

General Grant Tree & Zumwalt Meadow

Visit the majestic General Grant Tree, celebrated as the "Nation's Christmas Tree." Take a crisp, peaceful morning walk through Zumwalt Meadow along the scenic boardwalk next to the canyon cliffs and rushing Kings River.

12:00 PM

Lunch & Drive Home

Have lunch in the park or foothill gateways, then begin the drive south back to Southern California via CA-99 and I-5 (about 5 hours / 290 miles).

5:30 PM

Arrive — Santa Ana

Welcome home! Your complete Sierra loop is complete.

PACKING & SAFETY CHECKLIST

- ☐ **Water:** 6 liters of reusable water capacity per person (mandatory)
- ☐ **Sunscreen & bug spray:** individual responsibility — everyone packs their own
- ☐ **First-aid kit:** supplied and managed by the trip organizer
- ☐ **Warm layers:** fleece/hoodie/pants for freezing Sequoia evenings — no sleeping bags needed since you're in hotels/Airbnb
- ☐ **Swim gear:** for Sand Harbor, Secret Cove, Skunk Harbor, and the Kaweah River — dry off fully before sunset on Day 3 to prevent hypothermia
- ☐ **Reservations:** Sand Harbor day-use parking reservation booked in advance for the holiday weekend (reservenevada.com)
- ☐ **Picnic supplies:** for Skunk Harbor — no restrooms or trash service on site, pack everything in and out

Sierra Ascent · Santa Ana to the Sierra Nevada and back · July 4–7, 2026